

What is a Jew? What is a Christian?

The identity of the modern Messianic Jewish Movement

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INTRODUCTION

History has shifted heavily from the days of Jesus of Nazareth to the modern-day culture. Influenced by Greek thought, impacted by the Renaissance, and shaped by the Age of Reason, postmodern thought has emerged as an era of redefining words. With it, some definitions have been rearranged, rethought, and reshaped. Evidence of this is the recent documentary by Matt Walsh titled: “What is a Woman?” In this documentary, Matt Walsh exposes post-modern culture, which is unable to define the basic concept of a woman. Trying to redefine every single word to human convenience has created an over-informed world, pushing intolerance as tolerance and making everyone unable to define the core concepts of humanity.

This paper will analyze the modern messianic Jewish movement in light of the postmodern culture. Is this another case of counterfeit evidence? Of piggyback riding in others’ history, practices, and religion for historic archeological evidence? The case could be made for other religions, such as Mormonism or Islam, but should it be made for messianic Jewish origins? Or is this a tragic case of redefining a basic concept of the Bible? Both Jews and Christians should not rush into rejecting messianic jews and, by doing so, fall into the post-modern trap of redefining words.

There are two primary approaches to understanding Messianic Judaism. One would be to bind the movement to a theological framework, which goes beyond the scope of this paper. If traditional, historic denominations cannot even agree on doctrine, judging messianic Judaism by doctrine will prove a slippery slope. This endeavor has been approached by esteemed teachers, such as Dan Cohn-Sherbok, John Fischer, Patrice Fischer, Arnold G. Fruchtenbaum, Brad H. Young, Walter Keiser, and many others.

The other one is based on identity. Upon entering the research, it becomes clear that two questions must be answered to define the movement correctly: What is a Jew, and what is a Christian? This paper will analyze the historic claim to messianic Jewishness and the modern movement, from its roots to its present expressions. At the end of the paper, a proposed response from a Christian perspective will be presented, addressing the question: Can there be such a thing as a Christian Jew or a Jewish Christian?

WHAT IS A JEW?

Answering this question could be as simple as a definition or as complex as a culture.¹ Given the complexity of the sources, a threefold explanation is presented.² To this day there is no consistent definition

(1) When examining Jewish religious law, or Halakhah, a straightforward definition is provided: a Jew is anyone who was born to a Jewish mother or who has converted to Judaism.³

(2) When examining scripture, the Israelites (referred to as Jews after the land division and exile, and could be used interchangeably) are essentially comprised of: a man (Jacob), a people (the 12 with tribes), and a land.⁴

¹ Arnold G. Fruchtenbaum, *Hebrew Christianity: Its Theology, History, and Philosophy*. (Tustin, CA: Ariel Ministries, 1983), 2

² Christopher Rowland, *Christian Origins: An Account of the Setting and Character of the Most Important Messianic Sect of Judaism*, Second Edition, (London: Society for Promoting Christian Knowledge), 2002), 9

³ David H Stern, *Messianic Judaism: A Modern Movement with an Ancient Past*, (Clarksville, MD: Messianic Jewish Publishers, 2007), 14

⁴ Fruchtenbaum, 6

(3) When looking at ancient texts (including the Bible), the definition of a Jew opens up to a rich culture, to a people with a history, following a God and practicing a religion based on the revelation through sacred texts. Rowland clearly states this reality:

a) Judaism in the first or any other century means reading the books of Exodus, Numbers, Deuteronomy and Leviticus.

b) The weekly sabbath gave a distinctive character to Jewish existence, as did those food laws enunciated in Scripture (e.g., Deut. 14).

c) Also looming large on the horizon of the first-century Jew was the Temple. The bulk of the legislation in the Torah focuses on it and the conduct of its liturgy.

d) As far as most Jews were concerned, laws concerning tithing and sacrifice necessarily impinged upon them.

e) What is more, Scripture laid down the observance of certain key festivals necessitating pilgrimage to Jerusalem (Lev. 23; Exod. 23:14ff.; Deut. 16).⁵

It is the Bible, as a holy, covenantal, and legal book, that defines the nature and identity of a Jew. Its civil life, dietary customs, family framework, and worship liturgy accompany everyone “born to a Jewish mother or who has converted to Judaism”.⁶ Jewishness is an ethnic entity tied to a covenantal promise that practices and follows a holy book to honor their God and return to Him in an eschatological hope of the kingdom of God.

And what is the purpose of this ethnic entity? Is it to be far superior to the earth? Is it to look down on all the nations? On the contrary, so that all nations that were scattered in Babel could come back to God. A light to the nations. Any accurate analysis of its purpose will conclude that the God of nations and all peoples look forward to the day when both Jews and Gentiles (nations) will gather in worship of the one true God.⁷ The non-messianic Jews, not knowing He has already come once, are still waiting. Meanwhile, messianic Jews, knowing and accepting Jesus, believe that He

⁵ Rowland, 10 (Emphasis added)

⁶ Ibid, 11

⁷ Ibid, 27

will come again when “all Israel will be saved.” This is the eschatological hope of the Jewish people: the kingdom of God coming through the Messiah.

The parting of ways from the Jews: The first schism

Unfortunately for messianic Jews, modern jews do not look at them as jews at all. When Jesus came, He came to His own people. Some accepted Him, and many rejected Him. This drove a schism between those who did believe and those who did not. David Stern refers to this as the olive tree theology. As noted in The Gospels and the Book of Acts, all describe all disciples and first believers as Jews. He made Jewish disciples, took the last Pesach, rose from the dead on the festival of First Fruits, and gave the Holy Spirit on Shavuot.

“The Messianic Jewish community grew—a hundred and twenty (Acts 1:15), three thousand (Acts 2:41), five thousand (Acts 4:4), “and their numbers kept multiplying” (Acts 9:31). The non-Messianic Jews reacted against the Messianic Jews, pushing them away from the center (Acts 4–9, 12). Meanwhile, the message spread to Gentiles—Cornelius (Acts 10), Antioch (Acts 11); see Figure 5C (50 C.E.).”⁸

While the olive tree grew, the natural branches began to separate and reject them for their belief in Jesus. The grafted branches grew, and the Jewish schism grew too. Nearing the time of the Jewish temple destruction, there were two leading groups of Jews: (1) The messianic believers, influenced by the teachings of Jesus, fled to the city of Pella to escape the destruction. (2) While the second group stayed behind through the destruction and the slaughter of nearly a million Jews (according to Josephus; fewer by other estimates). This provided a more rigid separation as they began considering traitors.⁹

⁸ Stern, 53

⁹ Ibid, 54

But what might have sealed the fate of the messianic movement was the second revolt, 60 years later. When Rabbi Akiva, also known as Shim'on Bar-Kosiba “Bar-Kochva,” awaited the Messiah—the promised star (kochva) of Jacob—the messianic community could not pledge allegiance (Emunah) and leave behind the true Messiah, Jesus.¹⁰

For this reason, the schism grew larger, and Jewish leaders. The Jewish remnant (meaning those who still regarded themselves as Jewish while believing in Jesus as the Messiah) declined significantly after that until the fifth century. The community probably disappeared with the seventh-century Islamic conquests when they were killed or forcefully converted to Islam.¹¹

WHAT IS A CHRISTIAN?

With the coming of Jesus, the purpose of the Jewish nation began to flourish, to be a light to the nations. it was a sect within Judaism¹² By the time of Acts 10, the idea of “messianic” gentiles began to arise, and the number of gentiles coming to the Lord of the Jews grew larger and larger. By Acts 15, the council of elders concluded that gentiles could remain gentile and did not need to convert (as proselytes had too before) to Judaism to follow the God of the Jews. This meant the God of the Jews was now also the God of the nations. From the time of the Tower of Babel to the time of Jesus, a people group was represented by a land, a community, and a god or gods they worshipped. The opening of a belief system to other people groups without conversion introduced a new concept: one can be part of a particular people group, remain in their own culture, and change

¹⁰ Stern, 53

¹¹ Juster, 20

¹² Fruchtenbaum, 36

beliefs. Thus, a new community was created, which was deemed the church, the followers of the way. As Paul eventually said, both Jews and Gentiles are one new man.¹³

So, what is a Christian? A messianic gentile. Protestants define the word in terms of belief rather than mere practice or membership.¹⁴ As David Stern put it, protestants define a Christian as: “a person (Jew or Gentile) who has turned from idols or unfaith to serve the living God through Yeshua the Messiah with all his heart and soul and strength, having accepted the truth of the whole Bible—consisting of the *Tanakh* [the “Old Testament”] and the New Covenant Scriptures (“New Testament”)—and having acknowledged Yeshua as Israel’s Messiah, and as his atonement for sin and Lord of his life.”¹⁵

Furthermore, Roman Catholics or Eastern Orthodox define a Christian in terms of community—those who belong to the church. In combining these two statements, the conclusion is the same as that of Acts 15. “The Church is a community, but only of persons saved by faith, which cannot be inherited from parents.”¹⁶ One who believes and belongs to the one new man created “In Christ”. A Christian is one who belongs “in Christ” regardless of one’s ethnical origin and cultural expression. Who places his faith and allegiance in the Lord Jesus, accepting His Kingship, Atonement, and Eschatological Hope.

¹³ Fruchtenbaum, 94

¹⁴ Markus Vinzent, “Jewish-Christian Relations: A Painful Split.” In *T&T Clark Handbook of the Early Church*, edited by Ilaria L. E. Ramelli, John Anthony McGuckin, and Piotr Ashwin-Siejkowski, (T&T Clark Handbooks. London; New York; Oxford; New Delhi; Sydney: T&T Clark, 2022), 20

¹⁵ Stern 18

¹⁶ Stern, 19

The parting of ways from the Christians: The second Schism

While the first Messianic schism originated from Jewish counterparts who rejected the messiah and the Jewish Messiah-believing community, the second schism was also seeded at the same moment. Many Hellenistic Jews and later many of the gentile believers took the destruction of the temple as a rejection of Israel.¹⁷ The Hellenistic culture arose within them, and the love of Greek philosophy permeated the early Church Fathers. There is a notable lack of writings that document how this happened; however, by the beginning of the second century, this was evident among the church fathers and others. A teacher called Marcion spoke against messianic Judaism by stating Christians cannot follow the Gospel of Jesus and the Law of Moses at the same time.¹⁸ The early church fathers highly esteemed Greek philosophy. While there were still teachers opposing those teachings, like Tertullian, who famously stated, “What indeed has Athens to do with Jerusalem?”¹⁹

However, the real problem was not the mere use of Greek philosophy, but the underlying principle of Gnosticism that permeated their thought process. As Plato famously coined, the real world is the abstract, and the physical world is a mere shadow of it. This eventually led teachers like Origen to over-spiritualize the words in the bible and the church to eventually over-spiritualize the significance of Israel, eventually superseding it with the church. The faithful Israel and the True Jew were stripped of their ethnicity and became only by “belief”.

¹⁷ Juster, 16

¹⁸ Tertullian, *Adversus Marcionem*, 1.19; Ante-Nicean Fathers, vol. 3 (New York: Cosimo Classics, 2007)

¹⁹ Tertullian, *Heretics*, 7; Ante-Nicean Fathers, vol. 3 (New York: Cosimo Classics, 2007), 246

While this could have been enough to drive a total schism, before the revolts and obviously before the Christianization of Rome and the establishment of Christianity as the official religion, pagan Rome required that any non-legitimate religions bow in worship to the emperor and the Roman idols. This was not the case for Judaism, as it was considered a legitimate religion, and as such, Christians happily grafted their beliefs onto Judaism. When the Jews revolted in AD 70, this privilege was lost, and any relation to Jewish roots was a cause for persecution.⁸ This event pushed the schism further as Christians became more inclined to be a good Roman citizen instead of a Jewish sympathizer.²⁰

The nail in the coffin came when Christianity finally became the official state religion of Rome in the fourth century. From one day to the next, the new concept of the one new man was shattered. Immediately, Christianity became the official religion of many gentiles non-believers and became an integral part of their culture. Gentile “conversion” was growing faster than Jewish believers could catch up to. Eventually, these new believers were so detached from Jewish roots that, combined with the teachings of a defeated Jewish people, it became impossible for a person to express publicly both Jewish and Messianic identity.²¹

Christianity underwent significant changes with the union of the church and the Roman state. Those who were persecuted became conquerors. Daniel Juster shows the symbiotic relationship of both had: “The state used the Church to extend its power, and the Church used the state and the power of the sword to foster its doctrinal orthodoxy. More than three hundred years of

⁸⁸ Magnus Zitterholm, *The Formation of Christianity in Antioch* (New Albany: Routledge, 2006)

²⁰ Juster, 17

²¹ Stern, 54

Christian witness, during which Christians gave up their lives before the sword but never used the sword to extend the Kingdom of God, came to an end.”²² With this combination came persecution²³ until the Second Council of Nicaea, where explicit canons condemned anyone maintaining a Jewish lifestyle while professing faith in Jesus.²⁴

WHAT IS A MESSIANIC JEW?

The Jewish Messianic movement of today is not the result of mere chance. Whether the reader believes it is a divinely orchestrated movement, as they do, or not is not the question. What is evident is that it has slowly but steadily been born. As a seed that is planted dies to rise again and bear fruit, the messianic Jewish identity that once died has now risen and is taking strength and beginning to show its fruit.

Nevertheless, the question remains: what is a Messianic Jew? For one part, the normative answer within the Christian community has been: while Jesus was a Jew, the Jews rejected him, they crucified Him, and He has now abandoned them. Let the Jews be Jews and Christians be Christians.²⁵ For the other part, the normative answer within the Jewish community has been y, while Jesus and His early disciples might have been Jews, He (or Paul) founded a new religion. Its roots and forms have been mixed and have nothing to do with Jews. Instead, they have killed and mistreated the Jews in the name of the cross. Let them keep their cross, and we will keep our God.²⁶

²² Juster, 28

²³ Eliezer Berkowitz, *Faith after the Holocaust* (New York: KTAV, 1973)

²⁴ Norman Tanner, *Decrees of the Ecumenical Councils* (Lanham: Shed and Ward, 1990), 787

²⁵ Stern, 44

²⁶ Stern, 42

It is embedded in the identity of the messianic Jew to rejecting this idea of either embracing Jewishness or embracing Jesus. Their primary identity is to live in the tension, to be thoroughly Jewish and entirely Christian (or how they preferred to be called, messianic). It is to the deepest core of their being to extend both arms to reach out from both communities and bring them together in one new person.²⁷ Theirs is the ministry of reconciliation. To tear down the dividing wall and to build bridges.

As David Stern simply puts it:

*“So then, who is a Messianic Jew? My first choice for a definition is:
A person who was born Jewish or converted to Judaism, who is a ‘genuine believer’ in
Yeshua, and who acknowledges his Jewishness.”²⁸*

While this simple definition could include the primitive seed of Hebrew Christians, the modern definition, as stated below, will narrow it down to only those Jews who decide to live a Jewish lifestyle (as stated in the section: What is a Jew) within the framework of *Torah*²⁹

As David continues to say: “Believing in Yeshua, the Jewish Messiah, is one of the most Jewish things a Jew can do. A Jewish believer in Yeshua is not faced with having to give up some Jewishness in order to be more Messianic or having to give up some of his Messianic faith to be more Jewish.”³⁰

THE HISTORY OF THE MODERN MESSIANIC JEWISH MOVEMENT

The modern seed: Before WW2

²⁷ Ibid, 4

²⁸ Ibid, 20

²⁹ Ibid, 21

³⁰ Stern, 24

The earliest effort to revive messianic Judaism after its decline was by the Moravians in Germany in 1735. Count Nikolaus Ludwig von Zinzendorf founded a congregation within the Brüdergemeine (the Brethren community), which promoted Jesus-believing Jews to practice and maintain their Jewish faith and identity. He referred to this group as a Judenkehille (Jewish community).³¹ This was a significant advance, given that the common theme was for Christians of Jewish descent to identify as “Hebrew Christians.” This was not a way of reviving their Jewish heritage, but rather a means of reaching out with the gospel to their Jewish families.

They formed missionary agencies such as: “the London Society for Promoting Christianity Amongst the Jews (1809), the Episcopal Jews’ Chapel Abrahamic Society (1835), the Hebrew Christian Alliance (1867)”³² Although the agencies did not aim to establish a Jewish practice, they began a dialogue between Hebrews and Christians. This interaction led to the creation of a Jewish-Christian synagogue in Poland, where Jesus-believing Jews could continue observing the Torah and Jewish customs.³³

These endeavors were made possible by the political freedom found in pluralistic democratic countries. These freedoms allowed some radical ideas of thinkers to materialize without fear of persecution. Count Nikolaus Ludwig von Zinzendorf was likely influenced by the writings of the Irish John Toland, published in 1718, which suggested that Christians from Jewish backgrounds might consider observing the Torah.³⁴

³¹ David Rudolph et al, edited by David Rudolph and Joel Willitts . *Introduction to Messianic Judaism: Its Ecclesial Context and Biblical Foundations*, (Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan, 2013), 25

³² Rudolph, 26

³³ Dan Cohn-Sherbok, *Messianic Judaism*, (London; New York: Continuum, 2000), 27

³⁴ Stern, 58

Something that began as an idea in John Toland's mind started to materialize in outreach to Jews in Holland and Germany as early as the seventeenth century and evolved into the Hebrew Christian movement in early nineteenth-century England. Within these efforts, the shell of Judaism began to crack. While it mainly reached marginal Jews, it was just the stem of the tree that is today the modern messianic movement.³⁵

What the movement is today began taking shape in the middle of the 19th century in England when, according to David Sedaca, "many outstanding Jewish believers in Jesus who began questioning the then prevailing principle that the corollary of accepting Jesus was the forfeiture of one's Jewish heritage... *Eventually, this led* to the formation of the first body of believers who recognized both their Jewish ancestry and their faith in Jesus as the Messiah of Israel. The name of this association was "Beni Abraham," Children of Abraham."³⁶

By the year 1867, an idea promoted by C. Schwartz of Trinity Chapel led to the creation of an umbrella organization that united all national Jewish believers under the Hebrew Christian Alliance and Prayer Union of Great Britain. This expanded to other parts of the world until it ultimately formed an international alliance in 1925, known as the Hebrew Christian Alliances, which subsequently established the International Hebrew Christian Alliance (IHCA).³⁷

Once this happened, many Jewish believers stopped fearing for their identity and began declaring their Jewish ancestry, establishing national alliances throughout Europe. Rabbi Isaac

³⁵ Stern, 74

³⁶ David Sedaca, "The Rebirth of Messianic Judaism." In *The Death of Messiah*, edited by Kai Kjør-Hansen, (Baltimore, MD: Messianic Jewish Publishers, 1994), 106–7

³⁷ Sedaca, 108.

Lichtenstein in Tapio-Szele, Hungary. The first Hebrew Christian Church in Buenos Aires, Argentina, was established in 1936. Just before the start of World War II there were 20 national alliances affiliated with the IHCA.³⁸

The contemporary movement: After WW2

The Jews did as the Jews do; they grew. Sedaca states: "Out of the ashes of the Holocaust and with the founding of the modern State of Israel, a new Jewish identity began to develop, and the Hebrew Christian movement was not immune to these changes. The term Hebrew Christian no longer properly defined Jewish believers in Yeshua; therefore, a more accurate way of expressing their Jewish identity and belief was found in the term Messianic Jew."³⁹

The last 50 years have once more shifted all cultural factors. Shifts in social, political and theological thought have given the messianic Jewish movement a breath of fresh air igniting and attracting attention within Israel and outside Israel giving David Stern (and many others a) confidence "that the Messianic Jewish community will be the vehicle for healing the worst schism in the history of the world, the split between the Christians and the Jews, while helping both to fulfill their God-given callings".⁴⁰

By 1986, two new international umbrella organizations were formed. The Union of Messianic Jewish Congregations (UMJC) and the International Alliance of Messianic Congregations and Synagogues (IAMCS). Today, both organizations represent over 200

³⁸ Ibid, 108.

³⁹ Ibid 109

⁴⁰ Stern, 4

Messianic synagogues.⁴¹ With this authority, the messianic Jewish definition of these umbrella organizations has permeated or influenced almost all messianic Jewish congregations.

The UMJC defines Messianic Judaism as “a movement of Jewish congregations and congregation-like groupings committed to Yeshua [Jesus] the Messiah that embrace the covenantal responsibility of Jewish life and identity rooted in Torah, expressed in tradition, renewed and applied in the context of the New Covenant.”⁴²

Within these organizations, some core values have been defined and centered mostly around the statement “The Jewish people are ‘us,’ not ‘them.’⁴³ An expanded version of these core values is presented below.

CORE BELIEFS AND PRACTICES

Messianic Judaism consists of believers in Jesus who maintain a Jewish lifestyle. It is part of the Church, expressing its faith in a way that aligns with Jewish heritage. They observe all biblical holidays, such as Pesach (Passover), Succot (Feast of Tabernacles), Shavuot (Pentecost), and others, which the people of Israel were commanded to celebrate throughout generations.⁴⁴

Messianic Jewish congregations have a variety of expressions, but mostly worship on the Sabbath, perform Jewish liturgy and other Jewish traditions while maintaining its membership is open to both Jew and gentile.⁴⁵

Torah and Tanakh

⁴¹ Rudolph, 31

⁴² Rudolph, 11

⁴³ Rudolph, 130

⁴⁴ Sedaca, 105

⁴⁵ Sedaca, 106

All messianic Jewish organizations hold that some level of Torah observance is either commanded by God or should be encouraged among Messianic Jews.⁴⁶ The level to which they have this distinction varies among them. They hold both the Old and New Testaments as authoritative and inspired by God, thus being God's word.

Gentile inclusion:

The degree of inclusion of gentile believers is highly debated and is being discussed at the moment as to what the role of non-Jews should be in Messianic synagogue life.⁴⁷

Rabbinic authority

Within Messianic Jewish national organizations, there is debate about the extent and nature of rabbinic authority regarding Jewish tradition. Some adhere to a high level of rabbinic authority, but none consider it to be scripture.

Ecclesiology

Mark Kinzer's idea of "bilateral ecclesiology" helps clarify messianic ecclesiology. It suggests that the one Body of Messiah, the ekklesia, takes two different forms: a Jewish version and a Gentile one. Messianic Jews believe the Bible backs this perspective and is consistent with God's everlasting covenant with the Jewish people.⁴⁸

⁴⁶ Rudolph, 120

⁴⁷ Rudolph, 121

⁴⁸ Rudolph, 303

CHRISTIAN RESPONSE

After reviewing what the messianic movement claims as its ancient history and the birth of the modern movement, one question remains: Can there be such a thing as a Christian Jew or a Jewish Christian?

Both communities have long regarded these words as antonyms and considered them impossible to combine.⁴⁹ While the Jews believe Christians took a false Messiah and added it to scripture, Christians believe Jesus fulfilled the Old Testament in His person and disregarded the Jews entirely. The thesis behind the entire Messianic Judaism identity is that both are wrong in this regard. Christians did not take a false Messiah, but at the same time, their Messiah does not make any sense without the Hebrew Scripture. The (non-messianic) Jews did not see their Messiah when He indeed came, but this did not mean He disregarded them.

Is this another case of counterfeit evidence? No. Instead, it is a case of a tragic redefinition of a Biblical concept. To be Christian (or messianic) is in an entirely different ontological category than to be a Jew. The most Jewish thing someone could do is to be a Christian, to be messianic. And the most Christian thing a gentile can do is to look at the light of the Jews and follow the Messiah, God of the Jews.

Can there be such a thing as a Christian Jew or a Jewish Christian? Yes. As said by the Orthodox Jewish president of the Jerusalem Prayer Breakfast, Rabbi Tuly Weisz, at their founders' dinner in 2025:

“As an orthodox Jew, I did not realize that believers consider themselves Jewish... there is no longer a binary definition of who is jew and who is Christian, there is a spectrum. All of them in

⁴⁹ Cohn-Sherbok, 87

the spectrum share a common fate, a blood covenant, and a common struggle. The Jewish community does not have an idea of how to grapple with it.”⁵⁰

He then continues to cite the story of Ruth the Moabite and how she became the matriarch of King David and eventually the ancestor of the Messiah.

“The Jewish people needed Ruth then and need Ruth now; we must not push the believers away but find ways that anyone in the spectrum can be a bridge between Israel and the rest of the world.”⁵¹

After carefully reviewing more than 40 sources, this paper concludes that not only can a Messianic Jewish movement exist, but it must exist. Messianic Judaism is not a new religion that piggybacks on Jews and Christians; it is a valid expression of both Judaism and Christianity, merging the best of both into one to be a light to both communities.

The real definition, intended by the Bible for the descendants of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, is and has always been of a Messianic Jew as a light to the nations. Before the actual coming of the messiah, it was the expectation of the messiah that drove them. Now, after He finally came, messianic Jews have the opportunity, not to overcome them but to build a bridge between them.

It is in the best interest of the body of Christ that a messianic Jewish movement has a voice and a seat at the table. There are hidden treasures in scripture that were intended for the Jewish mind that could not be uncovered until they are seen through the messianic lens. Just as Daniel Juster says:

“The Messianic Jewish Movement has added new perspectives to understanding Yeshua that the Church is benefitting from. Messianic Jews are called to honor that which is good and right in the Church, to learn from its leaders, and to benefit from the study of the Church’s teachings, liturgy, traditions, and hymnology.

⁵⁰ Rabbi Tuly Weisz, “Rabbi Tuly Weisz - Founders Dinner - JPB 2025 Jerusalem”, 2 June 2025 at <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1paOKD0AJeY>

⁵¹ Ibid

If we do this, we will be astonished at the treasures awaiting us because it will enhance the development of Messianic Jewish tradition and expression.

If Messianic Judaism is to mature, it will not happen without a deeper appreciation of the Church, as well as its own Jewish heritage. And, if the Church is to fulfill its calling, it must embrace Israel, the Jewish people and Messianic Judaism.”⁵²

To respond correctly to the social and theological challenges posed by the resurgence of the Messianic Judaism movement, the church must listen to them. They do not ask for a special position; they simply seek recognition. As there was once a Jerusalem council that validated a Gentile identity that followed a Jewish God, the Messianic Jewish community is now calling for a second Jerusalem council, where a validation of Jewish heritage would be recognized as a valid expression of the body of Christ.

For centuries, messianic Jews have endured ecclesiastical authorities pressuring them to deny and reject their covenantal heritage and assimilate into gentile Christianity. Even today, a look at the X platform or any social media will show Christians insulting Jewish believers because they have chosen to remain authentic to their Jewish faith and practices. It is this faith in their messiah with a heritage of a victorious people that rises from the ashes that should compel the Christian community to stop and hear them.

The call Toward Jerusalem Council II

In 1996, this call to a new council was formed and called Toward Jerusalem Council II (TJCII) as “an initiative of repentance and reconciliation between the Jewish and Gentile segments of the Church.” In their minds, the second council would be made up of, not jews but gentile leaders of the body of Christ that recognize them as believers without needing to abandon their

⁵² Juster, 89

Jewish identity and lifestyle⁵³. For this purpose, they have created 7 affirmations they would like to see Christian churches adopt.

1. “We affirm the election of Israel, its irrevocable nature and God’s unfinished work with the Jewish people regarding salvation and the role of Israel as a blessing to the nations.
2. We affirm that Jews who come to faith in the Messiah, Jesus, are called to retain their Jewish identity and live as part of their people in ways consistent with the New Covenant.
3. We affirm the formation of Messianic Jewish congregations as a significant and effective way to express Jewish collective identity (in Jesus) and as a means of witnessing to Jesus before the Jewish community. We also affirm Jewish individuals and groups that are part of churches and encourage them in their commitment to Jewish life and identity.
4. We affirm our willingness as an ecclesiastical body to build bridges to the Messianic Jewish community; to extend the hand of friendship and to pray for their growth and vitality.
5. We affirm our willingness to share our resources with Messianic Jewish congregations, mission organizations and theological training institutes so as to empower them to fulfill their God-given purpose.
6. We affirm our willingness to be a voice within our own ecclesiastical structures and spheres of influence against all forms of anti-Semitism, replacement theology (supersessionism) and teaching that precludes the expression of Jewish identity in Jesus.
7. Finally, we affirm that as Jewish and Gentile expressions of life in Jesus grow organically side by side with distinct identities that God will be glorified; that the Kingdom of Heaven will be advanced and that the vision of “the one new man” in Ephesians 2 will unfold as part of the original Abrahamic blessing to the nations.”⁵⁴

It is time for the church to lay down its arms against the Jewish people and affirm its identity. Completely Jew, Completely Messianic.

APPENDIX

As for this author, let me tell you about myself in the first person...

⁵³ Rudolph, 139

⁵⁴ Rudolph, 142

I was born and raised as a Muslim for the first 20 years of my life. Then everything changed. My identity, my purpose, my actions, and my life were given to Him who gave it for me. I met the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Truly, for me, it was a radical change. I had to look at “my brother Isaac” and believe he is the son of promise, and I had to look at Jesus and believe he is not only the prophet but the one true God.

I believe I find myself in a position to understand both Jews and Christians in the struggle. I do come from a religion that hijacked their history, scripture, and ancestry to twist it and make something it is not. However, the place where I came to know the Lord is not the same as a traditional Christian's. I left my tradition, my family, my religion, my truth to follow the God of “my enemy,” the Christians. I understand the loss and difficulty of leaving one’s heritage, and it should not be asked of anyone who does not need to do so.

Now I find myself looking at a Messianic Jewish Movement and loving my other enemy. What is worse for a Muslim than becoming a Christian? Loving the Jew. But what is worse for every single human? To hate what God loves. He loves the Jewish people; he chose Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob so that all nations would be blessed through them.

Now I have a path to follow. To follow him in the reconciliation of Isaac and Ishmael before the return of the Lord. To prepare the way for his return, follow the ministry of reconciliation.

Like Jacob and Esau, who encountered each other on the way to the Promised Land, and Esau welcomed Jacob with gifts, hugs, kisses, and protection, I believe it is my calling (as a gentile) to welcome Isaac with love, security, readiness, and unity in the one new man. And in this unity, to declare to the world that He is the one true God.

I am now the director of our Bible school and serve as the youth pastor at our church. I used to think I needed to dive deep into historical studies, find the missing piece, and present the gospel

in a fresh way. Today, after reading this paper, I believe I no longer must follow that path. Or at least, not alone.

By affirming the right to exist of the Messianic Jewish movement, I can now learn from them and uncover the treasures meant for their eyes, ears, and hearts. I am eager to find a Messianic synagogue in my town and honor their heritage while serving in a local church. I am also eager to show this research to my wife and colleagues. To introduce them to the history and modernity of the movement. But more importantly, to hear them together, affirm their needs, and walk towards a Jerusalem council II.

What does an ex-Muslim do by following the God of the Jews in a Christian church? Teach the truth and the whole truth. Walk in the path of unity and reconciliation toward one new man. In the coming years, I will examine messianic literature and teachings, and, as the Bereans validated them with the Bible. While at the same time teaching our youth to honor what God chose to honor by blessing Israel and those who follow their Messiah.

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